

The Harlem Renaissance

A Comprehensive Educator's Guide

Why this matters: The Harlem Renaissance was one of the most significant cultural explosions in American history — a flowering of Black art, literature, music, and intellectual life that changed what it meant to be American. For Catholic school students, it is also a story of human dignity, perseverance, and the God-given creativity that flourishes even in the face of injustice. This exhibition brings that story to life through primary sources, interactive exhibits, and rich cross-curricular connections.

OVERVIEW

About this exhibition

The Harlem Renaissance (approximately 1920–1935) emerged from the Great Migration, when over one million Black Americans moved north from the Jim Crow South seeking better lives. In Harlem, New York, they built a remarkable world of culture, intellect, and art that would reshape American identity forever.

The Mini Museum's Harlem Renaissance exhibition features five interactive exhibits that students can explore in person and online:

01 The Electric Phonograph & Bessie Smith

A 3D interactive phonograph with authentic 78 RPM recordings of Bessie Smith — the Empress of the Blues — plus historical context on the birth of the recording industry.

02 The Fire in the Flint — Walter F. White (1924)

An interactive first edition of Walter White's landmark novel, with his biography as one of the NAACP's most influential — and least known — leaders.

03 The Jazz Lab

Three activities: Build a Band (assemble a jazz ensemble), Jazz Studio (arrange real audio loops), and Name That Instrument (12-round quiz). Over 150 audio loops drawn from period styles.

04 The Great Migration Map

An animated SVG journey from the Mississippi Delta through New Orleans, Memphis, St. Louis, and Chicago to Harlem — with historical photos and period music at each stop.

05 Harlem in Words

An interactive poetry workshop using word banks drawn from six thematic categories — Dreams, Nature, Music, Emotion, Action, and Harlem itself — to create original poetry in the Renaissance tradition.

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION

Option 1 — Visit the exhibition: If the Harlem Renaissance exhibition is available at your school, visit the Mini Museum to experience the physical artifacts and interactive exhibits firsthand. Contact your school librarian to arrange a class visit.

Option 2 — Virtual visit: Explore the full exhibition online.

minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

What students will learn

Across all grade levels and subjects, this exhibition develops the following core understandings:

- The Great Migration transformed American demographics, culture, and history between 1910 and 1970
- The Harlem Renaissance produced enduring literature, art, and music that shaped American identity
- Jazz and blues were original American art forms born from the African American experience
- Human dignity and creative expression flourish even under — and in response to — injustice
- Individuals can change history: writers, artists, musicians, and activists each played a vital role
- Primary sources — novels, music, photographs, maps — are windows into lived historical experience

STANDARDS ALIGNMENT

Cross-curricular standards

CCSS.ELA-LITERACY RI.6-8.1, W.7.3	Cite textual evidence, analyze primary sources, write narratives drawing on historical context
NCSS Standard I (Culture)	Understand how culture influences behavior, beliefs, and practices; analyze cultural contributions
NCSS Standard II (Time, Continuity)	Understand historical causation; connect the Great Migration to present-day demographics and culture
National Arts Standards MU:Re7.1, VA:Re7.1	Perceive and analyze artistic work; connect music and visual art to historical and cultural context
AASL I.B.1 / I.D.2	Use evidence to investigate questions; evaluate information for accuracy, validity, and context
Catholic Identity · CST — Human Dignity	Recognize the inherent dignity of every person made in God's image; understand justice as a Gospel value

HISTORICAL BACKGROUND

Context for educators

THE GREAT MIGRATION (1910–1970)

Over six million Black Americans left the South in two waves, escaping Jim Crow laws, sharecropping debt, and racial violence. The first wave (1910–1940) brought over a million north, with Harlem becoming the destination of choice for those heading to New York.

By 1930, Harlem held 175,000 Black residents — a self-contained world of Black-owned businesses, newspapers, churches, and cultural institutions.

THE RENAISSANCE (C. 1920–1935)

What emerged was extraordinary: Langston Hughes and Zora Neale Hurston transformed American literature. Duke Ellington and Bessie Smith defined American music. Aaron Douglas fused African aesthetics with Art Deco modernism.

The movement ended with the Depression, but its impact — on literature, music, civil rights, and American identity — proved permanent.

PRE-VISIT ACTIVITIES

Preparing your students

01

The Sound of History (5–10 minutes)

Play a short clip of Bessie Smith or Duke Ellington — many recordings are freely available on YouTube or Smithsonian Folkways. Ask students: *"What do you notice about this music? How does it make you feel? What do you think was happening in the world when this was recorded?"* Don't give answers yet — let them wonder.

02

Map the Journey (10 minutes)

Show students a blank map of the United States. Ask them to mark where they think large numbers of Black Americans lived in 1910. Then show the actual migration patterns — north to Chicago, Detroit, New York. Discuss: *"Why might people leave their homes? What would make the risk worth it?"*

03

The Name on the Spine (5 minutes)

Show students the cover of *The Fire in the Flint* (1924) by Walter F. White. Ask: *"What do you know about this book? Have you heard of Walter White?"* Almost no one will have. Then reveal: this man was one of the most important civil rights leaders of the 20th century — and he looked completely white. Let the paradox sit.

04

What Is Jazz? (5 minutes)

Write on the board: *"Jazz is America's classical music."* Ask students to agree or disagree and explain why. After discussion, add: it was also the first music created entirely in America, by Americans — and it changed music worldwide forever.

GUIDED QUESTIONS

During the exhibition

AT THE PHONOGRAPH

- What was it like to hear recorded music for the first time?
- Why might Bessie Smith's voice have been called "the Empress of the Blues"?
- What emotion do you hear in the music?

AT THE MIGRATION MAP

- How far is the Mississippi Delta from Harlem?
- What changed at each city along the route?
- What would you bring if you were making this journey?

AT THE JAZZ LAB

- How many instruments make up a jazz ensemble?
- What happens when you remove one layer?
- Can you identify each instrument by sound alone?

AT HARLEM IN WORDS

- Which word category feels most powerful to you?
- How do poets use line breaks to create meaning?
- What would Langston Hughes write about today?

> A NOTE ON PHYSICAL ARTIFACTS
>
> If students are visiting the physical exhibition, encourage them to handle artifacts carefully and respectfully. The phonograph, first edition books, and period photographs are primary sources — they connect us directly to the people who made this history. Treat them as you would any sacred object: with attention and gratitude.

POST-VISIT ACTIVITIES

Extending the learning

ELEMENTARY (PREK–4)

My Migration Story: Discuss that many families have moved — from another country, state, or city. Students draw their family's journey on a simple map and share one thing that changed and one thing that stayed the same.

Listen & Draw: Play a short jazz piece. Students draw what they hear — shapes, colors, feelings. No right answers. Discuss how music can paint pictures.

MIDDLE SCHOOL (GRADES 5–8)

Primary Source Analysis: Using the SOAPSTONE method (Speaker, Occasion, Audience, Purpose, Subject, Tone), analyze an excerpt from *The Fire in the Flint* or a poem by Langston Hughes.

Parallel Timelines: Students create a timeline comparing world events (1920–1935) with Harlem Renaissance milestones. What was happening elsewhere while this flourishing occurred?

ASSESSMENT IDEAS

Checking for understanding

- **Exit Ticket:** *"Name one person from the Harlem Renaissance and explain what they contributed."* (Simple recall, any grade)
- **Think-Pair-Share:** *"Why do you think this period is called a 'Renaissance'? What does that word mean, and does it fit?"* (Grades 3+)
- **Quick Write:** *"If you had been living in Harlem in 1925, what would you most want to create — a poem, a song, a painting, or a speech? Why?"* (Grades 4+)
- **Research Project:** Choose one figure from the Harlem Renaissance, research their life and work, and present to the class in role as that person. (Grades 5+)

RECOMMENDED READING

Resources for educators

FOR TEACHERS

- *The Harlem Renaissance* — Steven Watson (overview)
- *When Harlem Was in Vogue* — David Levering Lewis
- *The New Negro* — Alain Locke (primary source anthology)
- Smithsonian National Museum of African American History and Culture: nmaahc.si.edu

FOR STUDENTS

- *The Weary Blues* — Langston Hughes (poetry)
- *Harlem's Little Blackbird* — Renée Watson (PreK–2)
- *Voice of Freedom* — Carole Boston Weatherford (Grades 3–6)
- *Josephine* — Patricia Hruby Powell (Grades 3–7)
- PBS LearningMedia: Harlem Renaissance unit resources

KEY TAKEAWAY FOR STUDENTS

The Harlem Renaissance happened because people refused to let injustice silence them. Writers wrote. Musicians played. Artists painted. Poets spoke. In a world that tried to tell them they were less than human, they responded with extraordinary beauty and truth. That is the power of the human spirit — made, as we believe, in the image of God.